Xpro India Ltd. (NSE: XPROINDIA) — Company Dossier — Masterclass Companion Book

A step-by-step narrative walkthrough and audio companion to Xpro India Ltd. (NSE: XPROINDIA) – Company Dossier: deconstructing the business engine, global historical parallels, ten-year financial forensics, both sides of the institutional debate, and the discipline of high-asymmetry execution.

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SESSION PRICE

₹1,142.20

NEW CAPITAL VERDICT

REJECTED

CURRENT HOLDING ACTION

NOT HELD — NOT HELD (0 shares); no current holding to trim or exit.

STAGE POSTURE

VALUATION WATCH ZONE (CONDITIONAL)

₹620.00-660.00

SCENARIO TARGETS

Bear ₹414.00 / Base ₹811.00 / Bull ₹1,674.00

PREFACE & CORE THESIS

REJECTED on price, not on the business. Xpro India is a survivor with clean accounts, an A-/A1 rating and a real capacitor-film franchise, rated CYCLICAL_CONDITIONAL in Pass 1 . At the 12 November 2026 close of ₹1,142.20 the shares trade at 76.0x trailing earnings, and our probability-weighted value of ₹865 is 24.3% below the close. Even a pullback to technical support leaves the ₹811 base case below the entry, so the 1.5:1 gate fails and ₹620-660 is a re-underwriting zone, not an order. XPROINDIA is not in the positions ledger, so the holding action is NOT_HELD and new cash stays in cash.

PROLOGUE

The Business, The Price & Our Independent Verdict

> *"“...we believe this is a short-lived interruption in a long-term journey.”"*
>
> — XPRO INDIA INVESTOR RELEASE, 6 NOVEMBER 2025, ON THE DELAYED BARJORA DIELECTRIC LINE

Before we dive into the chapters, let me give you the whole story in one sitting, the way I would at the start of a long lunch. Xpro India is a Birla-family company that makes two things you will never see on a shelf. One is a hair-thin plastic film that goes inside the capacitors that smooth the electricity in your fan, your refrigerator, a solar inverter or an electric car. The other is ordinary plastic sheet that gets heated and pressed into the inside walls of refrigerators. Most people hear 'plastic film' and imagine snack packaging, and the Managing Director goes out of his way to say it is not that .

Why does a company like this deserve a ten-chapter study? Because it is in the middle of a bet. Between 2024 and 2027 it is spending roughly ₹700 Cr, more than its entire annual revenue of ₹505.5 Cr, to build two new film lines and take capacity from 4,000 tonnes to 13,000 . If the bet works, it becomes India's scarce supplier of a product the country mostly imports. If it does not, shareholders own a plain-plastic business with a very large depreciation bill.

Here is where I come out, and I want to be plain about it. My verdict for new money is REJECTED. Please hear what that does and does not mean. The business is real: clean audits, an A-/A1 credit rating, repaid banks, a franchise customers had to qualify before buying. But on the 12 November close of ₹1,142.20 the stock sits at 76 times last year's earnings and 3.5 times book value, for a company that earned 3.8% on its capital in the latest year. When I weighed three possible futures, the average came to ₹865 a share, about 24% below the price .

The two sides deserve their strongest arguments. The bull says: revenue rose 47% in the September quarter, the new line is making money, India imports 70% of this film, and if management simply meets its own targets the company is worth today's price at only 25

times profit. The bear says: you are paying for that success before it arrives, the company has been late with every new line, there is about 50% more Indian capacity coming than the country needs, and the return on capital has fallen from 21% to 3% while the spending went up. Notice that both are describing the same facts. They differ on the price you should pay for the uncertainty.

You may be wondering what you should do with that. If you do not own the stock, nothing; the ledger confirms there are no Xpro shares in your account, so no selling and no stop to set. Keep the next spare rupee in cash. If you want to revisit, I have written the conditions down: a price around ₹620 to ₹660, where my numbers would offer one and a half times as much reward as risk with a stop at ₹560, or proof that the new lines are filling at a profitable margin, ideally with the price nearer ₹1,020 than ₹1,140.

One last thing, about honesty. The chart has bounced hard from its March low and a 13 November print of ₹1,190.10 looked better still, but it came on thin volume and just under a flat 30-week average, so I would not treat it as a signal . I held myself to one rule throughout: judge the business first, without looking at the price, and only then ask whether the price is fair. Chapters 1 to 6 were written blind. Chapters 7 to 9 are where the price enters.

> **NARRATOR'S REFLECTION**
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> The hardest sentence in investing is 'good company, wrong price'. It feels like a contradiction until you see that a price is a promise about the future, and this one is a promise that nothing will slip. Keep the verdict and the business quality in separate boxes, and you can respect one while declining the other.

CHAPTER I

How the Business & Stock Got Here — Past Cycles & Pivots

> *"“It was to be expected that interest and depreciation burdens will exert significant pressure on the bottom line.”"*
>
> — XPRO INDIA DIRECTORS' REPORT, ANNUAL REPORT FY2014-15, ON THE FIRST DIELECTRIC FILM LINE

Let me start with a question you should ask about every company you study: what has it already survived? Xpro India was born on paper in November 1997 as Biax Films and renamed itself Xpro in September 1998. Its plants arrived through a court-sanctioned demerger from a Birla group company called Cimmco Birla, approved by the High Courts of Calcutta and Madhya Pradesh in 1999 . It has traded on the National Stock Exchange since April 2004 . Notice how ordinary that sounds. Nothing in this origin story hints at a capacitor-film specialist.

The plants came first. Faridabad opened in 1984, Barjora in 1991, Greater Noida and Pithampur in 2003 and Ranjangaon in 2008 . Two industrial processes sit under the Xpro name. One is BOPP, short for biaxially oriented polypropylene: you melt plastic, then stretch the film in both directions until it is thin, strong and flat, and at Barjora the technology was originally sourced from the United Kingdom and later developed in house . The other is coextrusion, which melts several plastics together into one layered sheet. Management is blunt about what this is not. As C. Bhaskar put it on 22 May 2026, “Xpro is not - I would like to emphasize on the NOT, a packaging products company as we are often considered to be” .

You will hear the Birla name and wonder whether this is the same family as Hindalco and the Aditya Birla Group. I looked, and I could not find that link in any filing. The promoter is Intellipro Finance, joined by iPro Capital, Birla Holdings, Birla Eastern and family members led by Chairman Sidharth Birla, and together they hold about 40% . That this is a different branch of the family is my inference, not something the company says. When a record is silent, I say so rather than fill in the gap.

Now picture 2015. Barjora's second line, the one that makes dielectric film, the thin polypropylene film that goes inside capacitors, has just been switched on. It is the biggest investment the company has ever made, and the directors write down their own warning: it was to be expected that interest and depreciation burdens would exert significant pressure on the bottom line . Around them the general packaging-film market was in oversupply, running at about 70% of capacity . Then, in July 2015, production at Pithampur "has been temporarily suspended … following inundation and consequent damage due to heavy rainfall and flash floods" . In November 2016 the Faridabad plant closed .

Here is the arithmetic that tells the story. Over four years the business earned ₹64 Cr of operating profit and paid ₹81 Cr of interest, a cumulative loss of ₹51 Cr . Debt peaked at ₹215 Cr . A company in that spot often ends up in a formal restructuring, called CDR, where lenders take losses and the process is public. Xpro instead rescheduled its loans with its State Bank of India-led lenders and a German bank, a rescheduling that the annual report says was "necessitated to overcome the strained cash flow position on account of losses" . It sold land and units to pay down debt. Even FY2018's reported profit of ₹10.46 Cr came from ₹21.88 Cr of asset-sale gains . You and I should not call that a recovery. Promoter-group entities also pledged shares in 2019 as extra comfort for the banks, and those pledges were released only in FY2024 .

Think about what clearing the decks looked like in practice. The Pithampur unit was sold on 9 June 2018 . Faridabad's land and some non-core Kolkata property went for about ₹42 Cr in FY2018 . Barjora's older packaging-grade line, Unit I, was restricted from FY2018, approved for sale at a shareholders' meeting on 16 April 2019 and finally handed over on 20 October 2022 for ₹6.78 Cr of fixed assets . Each of those decisions shrank the company, and each moved it away from commodity packaging film toward dielectric film and coextruded sheet. That is the quiet strategic result of the loss years: the portfolio you see today was shaped by the plants that had to go.

The real recovery came after 2019, and how it happened matters. Between FY2018 and FY2023 dielectric sales more than doubled, but tonnage rose only about 11% . In plain English, the company did not sell much more film; it sold better film at higher prices, roughly ₹228 a kilogram rising to ₹439 by my arithmetic . Covid brought a six-month loan

moratorium, but management withdrew its restructuring proposal when cash flow proved enough . By FY2022 the rating agency saw EBITDA of ₹63.8 Cr at a 13.5% margin, and net leverage had fallen from 5.3 times to 1.08 times in two years . By FY2023 debt was ₹39 Cr, and the company said “all normal long term loans” were repaid “well before schedule” . The agency lifted the company from BBB to A- over 2021 to 2023 . That is real evidence of resilience, and I do not want you to underrate it.

Put the whole cycle on one line. Revenue compounded about 8.8% a year from FY2015 to FY2023 and has been flat since. Operating margin climbed from about 1% to a peak of 14.5% in FY2023 and then dropped to 6.3% in FY2026, while profit after tax fell by more than half from its FY2023 level . The company’s own EBITDA, before currency effects, was ₹47.4 Cr in FY2026 . A business that was shrinking its debt a few years ago now reports a lower profit on a much bigger balance sheet. Keep that gap in mind; the rest of the book explains it.

Next, the capital. Between January 2022 and February 2024 the company raised ₹439.95 Cr from shareholders in three steps . Two were rounds of warrants, which are options an investor pays part of the price for upfront and converts into shares later, at ₹762 in 2022 and ₹975 in 2024. The third was a qualified institutional placement, or QIP, a quick route to sell shares to large institutions, at ₹1,101 for ₹150 Cr . A bonus issue of one new share for every two held was added in July 2022 . The result is that shares outstanding went from about 1.18 crore to 2.35 crore, a rise of about a third once the bonus is set aside . The promoters did not sell; their percentage fell from 51.4% to 40.3% because new shares went to other people . Malabar India Fund, a foreign portfolio investor, is the largest outside holder at 11.33% .

It helps to know who bought. In the 2022 warrant round, Malabar India Fund took 16,40,000 of the 19,68,000 warrants and two promoter-group entities took the other 3,28,000 . The 2024 warrants went to 12 subscribers, including more Malabar entities and the two promoter-group entities, and the QIP went to 21 institutions . I am describing a capital transaction here, nothing more: these were the people the company chose to sell new shares to, at the prices the company set.

The annual report for FY2024 told shareholders these issues “marked the end of our foreseeable capital-raising actions” . Keep that sentence in mind, because in December 2025 the UAE subsidiary sold 15% of itself to an Abu Dhabi investor . The parent kept its word; its subsidiary simply did not need to.

Now to the pivot. The money was meant to build new dielectric lines. Barjora’s second line doubled Indian capacity from 4,000 to 8,000 tonnes a year and was capitalised at ₹212.34 Cr, about three-quarters of the ₹284.61 Cr estimated in the placement document . A third line is going up at Ras Al Khaimah in the UAE, announced at “over AED 100 million” and carried at ₹360 Cr of work-in-progress by September 2026, which is roughly AED 140 million by my arithmetic . Work-in-progress, or CWIP, is simply money spent on a plant that is not yet producing, and it earns nothing until it is switched on.

Then look at the dates. On 29 May 2024 management said, “We should be operational definitely in the third quarter of the current fiscal” . Commercial production was declared on 27 March 2026, about fifteen months later . The board wrote in the FY2026 annual report that “the earlier delays in the project were externally driven and are behind us” . The UAE line has since slipped past its August-September 2026 trial date, and it is already at least eighteen months behind its first public date . Earlier, in November 2025, the company had written that “the Board and management understand and share shareholders’ disappointment during this trying phase” .

The slippage did not arrive in one blow. In May 2023 management expected the first new line to contribute in FY2025 and the second in FY2026 . In May 2024 that became the third quarter of FY2025. In May 2025 an analyst asked whether commercial production would start by September and the answer was that this was “a reasonable assumption” . By November 2025 the company said the formal start-up had taken longer than planned because of external factors . Each date was missed by a few months, and the misses added up to more than a year. That pattern, not any single delay, is what I would ask you to remember.

One more fact balances the picture. India Ratings affirmed the company at A- with a stable outlook and a short-term grade of A1 on 14 January 2026, and it assigned ₹195 Cr of bank facilities in total . The company also says it has been “continuously profitable since 2017-18” . A rating agency looks at the same history you and I are reading, and it did not

downgrade after the delays. That is not a guarantee of anything, but it is evidence that lenders still see the balance sheet as sound.

Now that the business history is done, let me show you the other half of the story, the price, which I deliberately kept out of the earlier chapters so that nothing about the market's mood could colour our reading of the company. Between its listing in 2004 and the spring of 2021, Xpro's stock never closed above ₹55.2 on the adjusted series, and on 23 March 2020 it touched ₹8.5. Then the dielectric earnings arrived, and in twelve months the price went from ₹48.7 to ₹1,075.8, a 22.1 times move . Ask yourself what it felt like to hold it through the next four years. Twice the stock lost about half its value from a peak: 49.9% between March 2022 and February 2023, and 50.3% between December 2024 and March 2026 . The second fall happened while Barjora's second line kept missing its start-up date, and EPS dropped from ₹17.04 to ₹8.19. The price had been paying for the ramp, and each slipped date made the market pay a little less for it. Since March 2023 the shares are up 65% even though earnings per share are down 67%, which tells you the market is buying the future and not the present. Hold that thought; Chapter 7 puts a number on how much of the future the price already contains.

Let me give you a way to hold both sides in your head. The bull reading is that this company has already survived worse. Its balance sheet carries net debt of only about ₹40 Cr against equity of ₹813 Cr, so a slow ramp is survivable . The skeptic's reading is that it has now built into a headwind twice. After the 2015 line came oversupply and losses; after the 2024-26 build came a fall in operating margin from 14.5% to 6.3% while volumes stood still and prices were cut 6-7% . Charlie Munger said, "Show me the incentive and I'll show you the outcome," and the incentive here is capacity, because a larger plant is the only way this business grows.

My own judgment, in one sentence: Xpro is a proven survivor and a poor forecaster of its own start-up dates. I would haircut management's schedules by about a year, and I would judge the programme on whether Line 2 reaches the 70-80% utilisation guided for the quarter ending March 2027, not on announcements . The share-price cycle continues into valuation and tape in Chapters 7 and 8.

NARRATOR'S REFLECTION

This company has already passed one hard test: it lost money for years, never restructured formally, and repaid its banks early. The second test is different. It is not survival but whether new capacity earns more than it costs. The history says Xpro will probably survive the answer; it does not yet say the answer is good.

CHAPTER II

Inside Every Segment — Products, Customers & Real-World Examples

> *""“Xpro is not - I would like to emphasize on the NOT, a packaging products company as we are often considered to be.”"*
>
> — C. BHASKAR, MANAGING DIRECTOR, Q4 FY2026 EARNINGS CALL, 22 MAY 2026

Before we go any further, let me clear up the biggest misconception about this company.

Most people hear “plastic film” and assume Xpro makes food packaging. Its managing director says otherwise, and he says it loudly: “Xpro is not - I would like to emphasize on the NOT, a packaging products company as we are often considered to be” . What it makes, in fact, is two very different things under one roof, and you and I need to keep them apart in our heads. One is a specialty film that goes inside electrical capacitors. The other is plain plastic sheet that ends up as the inside wall of a refrigerator.

Here is the accounting wrinkle that shapes everything in this chapter. Xpro reports a single audited segment, which it calls Polymers Processing, in a single country, India . That means the company never tells you how much profit each division makes. You get revenue by product, tonnes by product, and a few remarks from management on calls, and that is all. So the picture I am about to paint is part audited fact and part our own arithmetic, and I will tell you which is which as we go.

Start with revenue. In FY2026 the company sold ₹505.49 Cr of goods. The plain-plastic side, meaning coextruded sheets, refrigerator liners and cast films, was about 72% of that, and the specialty capacitor film was about 27% . Now look at the four-year trend, because it surprised me. Total revenue is flat. The specialty film has shrunk by about 13% since FY2023, from ₹156.35 Cr to ₹135.52 Cr, while the plain plastic grew a little . The expansion programme is built around the smaller, shrinking half of the business. Hold that thought.

Why did the film shrink? Not because customers walked away. Volume has stood almost still at about 3,550 tonnes for four years, because the one old line at Barjora is running near its ceiling at about 88% of its 4,000-tonne nameplate . What fell was the price: from about ₹430 a kilogram of film in FY2023 to about ₹383 in FY2026, by my arithmetic. Management

admits it cut prices by 6-7% on purpose, “in anticipation of the creation of new capacities” . A company that cuts its own price when it cannot make more is protecting its customers before the competition shows up. Sensible, perhaps, but not what a price-setter does.

Now for the newest evidence. In the six months to September 2026, total production rose 14% and revenue rose 32.6% to ₹351.1 Cr, and in the second quarter capacitor-film revenue grew 64% from a year earlier while sheets and cast films together grew 41% . Refrigerator sheet and liner volumes rose 18% for the half, against an industry up 4% in the first quarter and 8% in the second, and exports rose to ₹17.09 Cr from ₹9.39 Cr . The company does not split the half by division, so we cannot see how much came from the new line. Here is a way to size it: if the second line runs at 80% of its 4,000 tonnes at ₹480 a kilogram, it is worth about ₹153.6 Cr a year by my arithmetic, within management’s own range of ₹150-200 Cr per plant .

Let me walk you through a real example, end to end. Imagine a company that makes capacitors for solar inverters. It does not buy raw plastic; it buys finished capacitor film, and Xpro tells us exactly who these buyers are: “Our customer is only the capacitor industry” . Filings name Super Electro Films, Dhruv Industries and Starion India, and the rating agency has named TDK India . This customer wants film that is thinner, because thinner film means a smaller capacitor, and a smaller capacitor means a lighter inverter. But it needs the same film every time. As management puts it, once the specification is changed, “the supply has to be consistent” .

So the customer orders a 3.5-micron film. A micron is a thousandth of a millimetre, so this is a sheet far thinner than a strand of hair. Management says this gauge is already approved by some key customers and sells for a little over ₹600 a kilogram . That means one tonne is worth about ₹6 lakh. Compare that with the roughly ₹475 a kilogram for ordinary film and the ₹900 or so management quotes for 3-micron film, and you can see why the whole programme is a bet on getting thinner .

How is the film made? Specialty polypropylene granules, bought from global producers because the grades needed are “not manufactured in India”, are melted and extruded into a sheet . The sheet is then stretched, including sideways on a machine called a stenter, a long oven with clips that pull the hot film wide, all inside a clean room. The big rolls are slit to the

width the customer wants. And because the plastic is imported, the plant holds about three months of stock, which ties up cash .

Now the part that makes this a business and not just a factory: qualification. A capacitor maker cannot swap film suppliers casually, because the capacitor has to survive tests that run 1,000 to 2,000 hours, and the time to approve a film can be, in management's words, "anything from zero to many months" . Payment is secured too: "In the very, very specialized business, all sales are on LCs" . An LC, or letter of credit, is a bank's promise to pay. The rolls then ship direct to the customer, mostly within India, with no distributors in between. The company is explicit: "we are in a B2B segment" . Exact container and logistics details are not disclosed.

Where does the capacitor go? Here is a point I want you to remember, because it is what separates the story from the base. Management says its films end up in EV inverters, solar and wind installations, grid equipment, railways and data centres . All true. But Chinese industry data quoted in an IPO filing suggests EV and hybrid film is only about 11% of world capacitor-film tonnage, and inverter film for solar, wind and storage in China about 5.6% . Fans, coolers, washing machines, air conditioners, lighting ballasts and power-factor equipment remain the bulk, and that traditional part is forecast to grow only about 2.3% a year . The growth is real, but it is the smaller part.

Switch now to the other half. Picture a refrigerator factory, either near Delhi or near Pune. It needs the plastic liner for the inside of the cabinet and the door. Xpro makes the sheet at Greater Noida or Ranjangaon, vacuum-forms it into the shape on automatic lines, and delivers it to the assembly line . Buyers named in filings include LG Electronics India, which the rating agency said was 18% of revenue in FY2022, Haier, Godrej & Boyce, Voltas Beko and IFB . Sheets and liners together were about 61% of FY2026 revenue .

What about price? A kilogram of liner sells for about ₹269, and a kilogram of sheet for about ₹105, by my arithmetic, because sheet is partly consumed inside the plant to make the liner . Management says these prices follow crude oil "more or less directly", so when polymer costs move, the price follows with a small lag . That is good for protecting the rupee margin and bad for growing it. Customers pay within about 120 days under the terms, and the company's debtor days were about 50 at March 2026 . The sheet side also has history: sales

jumped about 34% in FY2025 after the company bought lines from a competitor, then fell about 12% in FY2026 . And it warns of customers integrating backward and making their own sheet .

The last Coex line is cast film, made at Ranjangaon on two lines. One use is release film for tyre makers such as MRL Tyre and JK Tyre; it stops uncured rubber layers sticking together. Others are the backing for diapers and sanitary napkins, stretch wrap and medical blister film . It is small: ₹54.70 Cr on 3,336 tonnes in FY2026, which is about ₹164 a kilogram . Production fell about 13% that year, and the company says cast films "continued to face competitive pressure" . One line has been revamped to focus on release film .

Now the fourth pillar, which has no revenue yet. In Ras Al Khaimah in the UAE, Xpro is finishing its first overseas plant through a subsidiary it now owns 85% of, after an Abu Dhabi investor took 15% . The plant should add about 5,000 tonnes and is meant to sell to the United States, Europe and the Far East, since management says America does not manufacture base dielectric film . Equipment is on site, dry runs start around December 2026, and commercial operation is expected later in the financial year .

Here is the question that matters most for you as an owner of this business: how much of the profit comes from the capacitor film? The company will not say. But we can do the arithmetic. Management says its capacitor film earns "between something like on the lower side 35% and going up to something like 55%" EBITDA, which means profit before interest, tax, depreciation and amortisation, and the plain-plastic side earns "in the 5% to 7% EBITDA range" . Take the plain-plastic side at those margins and subtract it from the group's audited EBITDA, and what is left for the capacitor film is a margin of about 30-35% in FY2024, 19-25% in FY2025 and 18-23% in FY2026 .

Run the test the other way. If the capacitor film really earned 35% and Coex 5-7%, FY2026 EBITDA would have been about ₹66-73 Cr. The company reported ₹49.2 Cr. At 55% the gap would be even wider . So either the film margin is well below the quoted range, or something large sits unallocated. My judgment: the 5-7% on plain plastic is credible, because it is a pass-through business and the arithmetic leaves little room. The 35-55% is better read as a contribution margin on conventional gauges at good prices, before shared costs, the price cuts and the cost of staffing the new lines. In FY2024 the implied margin was already

below the “over 40%” management had cited . I would put the fully loaded margin on the old line at roughly 20-30%, an estimate and not a disclosure. The new line lost about ₹7 Cr in the June 2026 quarter, narrowing by about ₹3 Cr in the next one, which shows how big the drag has been .

Finally, concentration. One customer, which the company does not name, was 29.6% of FY2026 revenue, up from 25.9% in FY2025 . That customer buys more than the entire capacitor-film business sells, so it is almost certainly a refrigerator maker, which I infer but cannot confirm. The top ten customers have been 72% to 76% of revenue in recent years . Exports are small, ₹22.45 Cr in FY2026, or 4.44% of turnover, to the United States and Germany for dielectric film and to Sri Lanka for sheet .

Warren Buffett wrote that “a truly great business must have an enduring ‘moat’ that protects excellent returns on invested capital.” Xpro’s capacitor film has the beginnings of one: tests, approvals and a handful of imported-resin grades. Its plain-plastic half does not. The bull case is that customers “want far more material than we have been able to supply” and Coex is taking share, with volumes up 26% in the September 2026 quarter against an industry up 8% . The skeptic’s case is that the film has been flat for four years, its price fell 11%, imports are still the larger share of the market, and a 29.6% customer on 5-7% margins gives little pricing power . You can hold both views at once, and I would.

> **NARRATOR'S REFLECTION**
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> Two businesses share one name. One is a qualified specialty film whose true profit the company will not disclose; the other is a plain-plastic sheet business with thin margins and a very large customer. The audited numbers say the specialty half has not yet shown the earnings its quoted margin implies. The next test is whether thinner film, sold at a higher price from larger capacity, finally shows up in the reported profit.

CHAPTER III

How It Is Sold & Delivered — Distribution & Unit Economics

> *"In the very, very specialized business, all sales are on LCs."*
>
> — MANAGEMENT, Q2 FY2027 EARNINGS CALL, 4 NOV 2026

Let us start with the simplest question a business can be asked: who writes the cheque, and when? For Xpro India the answer is unusually plain. There is no dealer network, no distributor and no wholesaler in the middle. The placement document says sales to major industrial customers "are direct through our own marketing teams", and the managing director put it more bluntly on 30 May 2025: "we are in a B2B segment. We are not in a sell to trade and supply market at all." That directness is a double-edged choice. It means no channel margin to share. It also means no cushion, because every rupee comes from a named customer. The top ten customers were between 71.7% and 76.4% of gross revenue in each period from FY2021 to early FY2024, and in FY2026 one customer alone paid ₹149.41 Cr, 29.6% of revenue .

Can you guess who that customer is? The company will not tell us, but arithmetic points one way. ₹149.41 Cr is more than Xpro's whole dielectric film book of ₹135.52 Cr, so it cannot be a capacitor maker; it is almost certainly a refrigerator maker or a group of them. That is our inference, not a disclosure . Keep it in mind, because it tells you which half of the business carries the concentration risk.

Now picture the two halves of the order book. On one side is dielectric film, the thin polypropylene film that sits inside capacitors. Capacitors are the small components that smooth and store electrical energy in fans, inverters, motors and electric-vehicle drives. The buyers are only capacitor makers and the firms that vacuum-coat film with metal, called metallisers . Each buyer tests the film in its own way. The managing director said validation "could be anything from zero to many months", and capacitor life tests of 1,000 to 2,000 hours are running at some customers today . Nothing is made for stock: the product is "produced against confirmed requirements, designed in consultation with the customers" .

And how do they pay? Here is the line I want you to underline: “In the very, very specialized business, all sales are on LCs.” An LC, a letter of credit, is a bank's promise to pay the seller once the shipping papers are in order. It turns a customer's promise into a bank's promise. No long-term contract, no take-or-pay clause and no order-book value is disclosed, and the placement document says customer prices are fixed “either annually or for the duration of the agreement” . So the security is in the payment, not in a locked-in volume.

The other half is plastic sheet and moulded refrigerator liners from Greater Noida and Ranjangaon, sold to white-goods makers on open credit, with terms that “generally falls within 120 days” . Standalone receivables of ₹69.22 Cr on ₹505.49 Cr of revenue work out to about 50 days (our calculation). Add cast films for tyre release and hygiene products, and exports of just ₹22.45 Cr, 4.4% of revenue, mostly dielectric to the United States and Germany and sheet to Sri Lanka . Notice something uncomfortable: the annual report itself warns of “selective backward integration by certain customers, including under PLI-supported schemes” . Your biggest customer may be thinking about becoming your competitor.

Turn now to what goes into the film. Resin is the cost that decides the year: ₹350.01 Cr of materials, 69.2% of FY2026 revenue . The capacitor-grade polypropylene is, in management's words, “highly specialized, highly specific grades not manufactured in India, even though India is a large polypropylene resin producer, that is mainly packaging types” . Worldwide, three producers make it: Borealis and Borouge, KPIC of Korea and TPC of Singapore . Xpro names Borouge as a supplier and says much arrives from Europe . It has no long-term agreements with most suppliers; price and quantity are settled order by order .

How big a customer is Xpro to those three? Using a Chinese rival's rule of thumb of 1.55 t of resin per tonne of film, FY2026's 3,541 t of film needed about 5,500 t of resin, 2.4% of world demand. At 13,000 t of film that rises to about 20,150 t, or 8.7% (our calculation) . It is a small buyer facing a few sellers, so we should not assume it can bargain. Management's answer is stock: “at any point of time, this being an imported raw material, we like to make sure we have at least 3 months of stock in the plant” . By our arithmetic the whole raw-material pile is only about 1.7 months of consumption, so the three-month rule seems to apply to the specialty grades, not to every input.

What happens when resin moves? Management is candid: “Sometimes you get the pass-through contractually, sometimes you have to work on the pass-through. It depends on customer to customer.” After the West Asia conflict lifted resin and freight, the verdict was that “the pass-on has been, I will say, not full yet” . You can see it in gross margin, which slid from 30.3% to 27.5% across a year of rising sales . The lag also works downward. When polymer cost fell 10% to 11% in FY2024, dielectric sales fell 6.7% on flat tonnage . The machines are the other bottleneck: for the core line there is “no Chinese alternate”, only three European builders, and commissioning “cannot be less than 2 years today” .

Now the part every analyst wants and the company declines to give: what does a kilogram sell for? In November 2026 the “modal price of film is around INR470, INR480 a kilo”, with 3.5 micron film at a little over ₹600 and 3 micron near ₹900 . Six months earlier the same range was “in excess of INR550 a kilo”, offered with the caveat “I'm just throwing a range” . The audited average is lower than both: ₹383 per kilogram in FY2026, down from ₹430 in FY2023 (our calculation) . So treat the quoted prices as an indicative band, not a data series.

That price decline was partly a decision. “We had taken a strategic decision and had worked towards a slight softening of prices in anticipation of the creation of new capacities.” On FY2024's dielectric revenue, a 6% to 7% cut is worth ₹8.8 Cr to ₹10.2 Cr, more than half of the ₹15.9 Cr fall in group EBITDA that year (our calculation) . Warren Buffett told the Financial Crisis Inquiry Commission in 2010 that “the single most important decision in evaluating a business is pricing power”. A company that cuts price while running near full capacity, to pre-empt competitors, has told you something about how much of it it has.

Next, the cash cycle. Look at the history: from FY2015 to FY2022 suppliers were paid slowly, around 83 days on average, so they financed the business and the cycle from paying for raw material to collecting from customers averaged 31 days. In FY2026 it reached 80 days. Inventory days went from 57 to 76, payable days from 68 to 46, and debtor days from 53 to 50 . Management explained the stocking: “if I can buy and stock for 3 months, I would”, tied to shipping risk through Hormuz . Meanwhile payables fell ₹27.6 Cr as purchases shrank . The result was that working capital absorbed ₹18.94 Cr, and cash from operations was only 43% of EBITDA . Add ₹15.7 Cr more in the first half of FY2027 as

receivables rose on 47% higher sales . It is the real carrying cost of importing a specialty resin, not an accounting trick.

Now follow the money on a single rupee. Take ₹100 of FY2026 revenue. Materials took ₹69.43, employees ₹7.44 and other operating costs ₹13.75, leaving ₹9.38 of EBITDA. Depreciation took ₹2.37, interest ₹1.49, and a small net other income of ₹0.48 left about ₹6.00 before tax and ₹3.87 after tax. Cash from operations was ₹4.04, but capex was ₹27.82, so free cash flow was a negative ₹23.79 . That is not leakage. About ₹116 Cr of the ₹140.65 Cr capex was the UAE plant, and the rest was the Barjora line and other standalone spending. Note, too, that other income of ₹18.21 Cr was almost wiped out by a ₹15.78 Cr foreign-exchange loss on the euro loans, mostly unrealised, so ₹2.43 Cr remained .

Now the comparison I promised, built only from management's own ranges and so purely illustrative. Imagine a ₹100 invoice for dielectric film and another for refrigerator sheet. Management says dielectric EBITDA runs 35% to 55% and coex 5% to 7% . So the dielectric invoice keeps ₹35 to ₹55 and the sheet invoice keeps ₹5 to ₹7. But backing the coex range out of reported FY2026 EBITDA leaves dielectric at roughly 16% to 23%, not 35% to 55% (our calculation). Even at that lower figure, a tonne of dielectric earns roughly 8 to 17 times the EBITDA of a tonne of sheet. You need about 114 to 163 tonnes of film to earn ₹1 Cr of EBITDA, against about 1,357 to 1,899 tonnes of sheet.

That is why the unit economics matter more than the headline sales. Group EBITDA per tonne fell from ₹26,708 in FY2023 to ₹15,127 in FY2026 while tonnes rose 12.5%, because the new tonnes were mostly sheet (our calculation). The extra Barjora line is supposed to reverse that. It must lift dielectric's share of tonnes, and thin-gauge films must lift the price per kilogram, before group economics resemble the management ranges. What is not disclosed is just as important: no segment profit, no named dielectric customers, no long-term contracts, no per-kilogram price history. We have ranges and back-calculations, and we should say so.

NARRATOR'S REFLECTION

A business can be secured at the point of payment and still be exposed at the point of price. Xpro's letters of credit mean it rarely worries about being paid for dielectric film; the FY2025 price cut, the three resin suppliers and the incomplete pass-through of resin cost show how little it controls on either side of the sale. Track the gap between what customers pay per kilogram and what resin costs per kilogram, because that spread, not the revenue line, is where the unit economics live.

CHAPTER IV

The Battlefield — Rivals, Switching Costs & Moat Reality

> *"could be anything from zero to many months depending on the specific customer and the specific application. Each customer has a different test cycle and a different standard of requirement for each of their capacitor applications."*
>
> — C. BHASKAR, MANAGING DIRECTOR, ON CUSTOMER VALIDATION OF DIELECTRIC FILM, Q4 FY2026 EARNINGS CALL, 22 MAY 2026

Before we judge whether Xpro has a moat, you and I need a map of the battlefield. Start with the size of the market. Reports from research vendors disagree by a factor of three, so I lean on the one source that counts tonnes: Chinese industry-association data quoted in the IPO filings of Quanzhou Jiadeli, known as JDL. World demand for the film that goes inside capacitors was 136,000 tonnes in 2024 and is forecast at 195,000 tonnes by 2029, about 7.5% a year .

Now, how much of that is the glamorous electric-vehicle and solar story? Less than you might think. On JDL's own assumptions, EV and hybrid film is about 14,900 tonnes, 11% of the 2024 market, and inverter film in China another 5% (our calculation). Traditional uses such as lighting, appliances and industrial control grow only about 2.3% a year . Most tonnage is ordinary industrial film, and that is where Xpro's fan, cooler and power-factor customers live . In India the demand is put at about 15,000 tonnes, roughly 70% of it imported . Xpro's own 3,541 tonnes is 24% of that, so its “about a third” share must be measured on a narrower base.

Who sits across the table? Toray of Japan makes 2.0-micron film at 125 degrees Celsius. A micron is a thousandth of a millimetre, and thinner film packs more capacitance into less space, which is why electric-vehicle makers want it. Tervakoski in Europe has just installed a new stretching line, and Chinese producers such as JDL, with 18,600 tonnes and a 46.6% gross margin, and Tongfeng, with 20,000 tonnes, play at scale . Treofan, a German name once called the gold standard of capacitor film, sent its Neunkirchen plant into insolvency in September 2025 . And here is the detail I find telling: every one of these rivals buys resin from the same three producers and stretching lines from the same three machine builders .

Look at the supply that is coming. JDL says producers will add about 20 lines and 55,000 tonnes in 2025 to 2028, against 59,000 tonnes of demand growth over 2024 to 2029 . That is near balance, with little room for a pricing mistake. In India the arithmetic is sharper. Xpro has 8,000 tonnes, JPFL Films 10,000 and SRF 4,500, which makes 22,500 tonnes against a demand figure of 15,000 . That is 1.5 times the market. Either the surplus is exported or demand must grow by about half, four to five years at the 8% to 10% management cites. Import substitution is a real runway, but Xpro is not alone on it.

What does it cost to join this club? Xpro's second Barjora line was capitalised at ₹212.34 Cr for 4,000 tonnes of capacity, or ₹5.3 lakh per tonne, and ₹6.0 lakh on management's own figure of "about INR240 crores" . SRF built 4,500 tonnes for about ₹277 Cr . A line takes about two years to arrive, and for the core machine there is no Chinese alternative . That is a real wall. But three Indian companies have already climbed it, and a wall that three rivals have climbed has told you something about how high it really is.

What about protection? There is none. No anti-dumping or safeguard duty on capacitor film has been found, and imports are effectively duty-free . Management says Xpro has competed "for the last few years without any tariff protection", and on trade remedies, "I believe antidumping will be reviewed as and when there is a threat or real dumping happening" . Packaging films are different: the regulator's final findings on PET film recommend five-year duties on three countries, citing global oversupply . Subsidies tilt against Xpro too. Dhruv Industries, Capfilm India and Enerfolie have ECMS approvals, SRF has disclosed an incentive for PP film, and Xpro, whose line was already on site before the schemes, has not applied: "we have not applied under any PLI scheme" . It will look at the next line. The size of the gap is not disclosed.

Let me show you how the operating numbers compare. Xpro's operating margin went from 14% in FY2022 to 6% in FY2026 on the aggregator's definition. The packaging-heavy peers, Cosmo, Polyplex, UFlex, Jindal Poly and Ester, each lost between 7 and 24 margin points from FY2022 to FY2024 and have recovered only partly. Garware, which makes specialty polyester film, held 17% to 21% through the whole cycle . Specialty positioning matters, and Xpro sits somewhere between the two groups.

So, is there a moat? Let us test it honestly, the way Warren Buffett framed the problem in his 1995 shareholder letter: “The dynamics of capitalism guarantee that competitors will repeatedly assault any business ‘castle’ that is earning high returns.” The first defence is qualification. The managing director says validation “could be anything from zero to many months depending on the specific customer and the specific application”, and automotive rules treat a change of base-film supplier as a re-qualification event . Resin changes take three months for thick film and about two years for automotive ultra-thin film . That is real. But SRF went from trial runs to commercial sales in about two to three quarters, JPFL has sold since 2022, and with about 70% of the country's film imported, buyers already qualify outside suppliers . Qualification keeps a new plant out for a while. It does not lock Xpro's existing customers in. Girish Behal, due to become managing director in January 2027, told analysts that a new entrant must “have the patience to at least get into the long qualification cycles” .

Picture the quality head at an Indian capacitor maker. Xpro's film has passed her tests. A Chinese supplier offers film that, on import data, averaged about 20% cheaper over a decade . If the part is a fan or cooler capacitor, some applications need only standard approvals of the process without long trials, and she can switch with modest effort . If it is an automotive DC-link part, the rule-book forces re-qualification, and the life tests alone run 1,000 to 2,000 hours . Her decision depends on the application, not on Xpro. That is why the moat is strongest in thin and automotive grades and weakest in the appliance film that is most of Xpro's tonnage.

The second defence, technology, looks weaker still. Xpro's film is approved at 3.5 microns with key customers, and 3 microns has been made but not sold commercially, while Toray, JDL and Tervakoski are at about 1.9 to 2.0 microns . The premium for thin film is steep, but you cannot earn a premium you cannot yet sell. The third, scale, is modest: 8,000 tonnes against JDL's 18,600 . The fourth, resin, is a shared dependency; Xpro is about 2.4% of world demand, a small customer for three powerful sellers . Certifications such as IATF 16949 are necessary but do not set Xpro apart. And pricing power? Xpro cut price by 6% to 7% in FY2025 while running nearly full, and in 2026 was still passing resin cost through only in part . Customers wanting more film than Xpro could supply is evidence of demand, not of pricing power.

Give the bull his best day. Xpro is the only scaled domestic producer in a market that still imports about 70% of its film. It has just doubled Indian capacity. Thin film sells at ₹600 to ₹900 a kilogram against a modal ₹470 to ₹480, JDL's 46.6% gross margin shows what the category pays at scale, and a cheap Chinese film is not an automatic substitute when the customer must run a 1,000-hour test. Management's own words on competition are candid: “some new competition has entered and is also expected to enter more” (Girish Behal, 4 Nov 2026) . The bull says the market is large enough for several players.

Now give the skeptic his best day. Standard film has no tariff. Indian nameplate is 1.5 times demand. SRF qualified in a few quarters, and Chinese film averaged about 20% cheaper over a decade . Xpro cut its own price. Backing the coex margin out of reported results, the dielectric margin implied by FY2026 fell from about 30% to 35% in FY2024 to roughly 16% to 23%, well below the 35% to 55% management range (our calculation) . It buys from the same resin and machine sellers as its rivals. And the managing director, who built the franchise, steps down on 31 December 2026 . Two slower threats sit behind that. Ceramic DC-link designs were found about 6.6 times smaller in a 2026 benchmark , though TDK says film capacitors are today the dominant solution for the main inverter in electric vehicles, so this is a slow risk, not an imminent one . And no one has yet shown a pricing-power moat in the numbers.

My own verdict, in plain words. In standard-grade film the moat is narrow and eroding; the evidence of price-taking, domestic oversupply and quick entrant approvals outweighs the evidence of lock-in. In thin, automotive and hazy grades the moat is not yet earned, because Xpro's best commercial gauge is a micron behind the leaders. It could widen if 3-micron film reaches commercial volume near ₹900 a kilogram and the long tests turn into repeat orders. I would change my mind on three things: a disclosed dielectric gross margin, evidence on whether SRF and JPFL volumes displace Xpro or imports, and thin-gauge sales.

Finally, three stories from other industries teach the same lesson from different sides. Ajinomoto's build-up film for chip packages holds more than 95% of its market at business-profit margins of 45% to 54%, but because the chemistry was proprietary and co-developed with customers, which Xpro's bought-in inputs are not . The Jindal group's film build-out shows the base rate: margins fell from 24.2% to negative, PAT lost ₹228 Cr and ₹306 Cr, and

the Neunkirchen plant went insolvent, though Xpro's far stronger balance sheet makes dilution of returns, not distress, the likelier risk . Yageo's 2018 shortage boom, with revenue up 139% and then down 46.5%, warns you not to treat a supply-shock year as normal, and 2026 is such a year for Xpro . The web edition's learning hub lists the primary sources, from the Xpro call transcripts to Brückner's video of a capacitor-film line, if you want to see the machine yourself.

NARRATOR'S REFLECTION

A moat is not a description of a product; it is a claim about what happens when a well-funded rival turns up. Xpro's qualification barrier is real but it gates entrants more than it holds existing customers, its thin-gauge frontier is a gap rather than a lead, and its own price cut told you what it expected from competitors. Keep asking one question of every new fact: does it show that customers pay more, or stay longer, because of something only Xpro has?

GLOBAL PARALLEL • JAPAN, 1999 TO 2026; INSULATION FILM FOR CHIP-PACKAGE SUBSTRATES • AJINOMOTO BUILD-UP FILM (ABF), AJINOMOTO CO. (MOAT_SCALING)

Ajinomoto, an amino-acid company, launched an epoxy interlayer film in 1999. It built the franchise through co-development with chip customers, proprietary chemistry and in-house manufacturing. It credits “a system for rapid development together with customers” for a share above 95% . Global share above 95%; Functional Materials business-profit margin guided at 45% for FY2024 and 54% in Q1 FY2024; electronic-materials sales ¥60.8 bn in FY2023, FY2024 guidance ¥74.6 bn (+22%); FY2023 still saw a large profit decrease when PC and server inventories adjusted . A qualified franchise can hold more than 90% share and 45%-plus margins for 25 years, but only because the chemistry was proprietary and co-developed. Xpro's two critical inputs, European lines and imported resin, are bought, and rivals buy the same. Its closest scaled twin is JDL, a dielectric-film specialist with eight Brückner lines, 18,600 t and a 46.6% gross margin in 2025. Xpro is below that scale and about a micron behind on gauge .

GLOBAL PARALLEL • INDIA AND EUROPE, 2013 TO 2026; BOPP AND BOPET CAPACITY ADDED THROUGH THE CYCLE • B.C. JINDAL GROUP FILM BUILD-OUT (JINDAL POLY FILMS, JINDAL FILMS, TREOFAN) (FAILURE_BASE_RATE)

The group bought ExxonMobil's BOPP business (2013) and Treofan (2018). It reached 311,000 t of Indian BOPP by 2020 and kept adding capacity into the downturn. A 2025 fire confounds the case, so we corroborate with sector peers . JPFL Films EBITDA margin 24.2% (FY2022), 9.7% (FY2023), -0.1% (FY2024); PAT -₹228 Cr (FY2024) and -₹306 Cr (FY2025); debt to EBITDA 8.4x in FY2025; Treofan's Neunkirchen plant, "only half utilised" on about €149 m revenue, filed for insolvency in Sep 2025. Across five listed Indian peers operating margins fell 7 to 24 points from FY2022 to FY2024 . Treofan was a capacitor-film "gold standard" supplier. It still failed because packaging dominated its accounts, an exposure Xpro avoids. The capacitor niche now has lumpy lines (₹5 to ₹6 lakh per tonne), two-year lead times, several domestic entrants and 55,000 t of global additions against 59,000 t of demand growth. Xpro's balance sheet is far stronger, so the likelier failure is diluted returns (RoCE 15.7% in FY2024 to 5.7% in FY2026), not distress .

GLOBAL PARALLEL • TAIWAN, 2017 TO 2019; THE MLCC AND CHIP-RESISTOR SHORTAGE CYCLE • YAGEO CORPORATION (PASSIVE COMPONENTS) (CYCLE_VALUATION)

A shortage led customers to panic-buy and suppliers to raise prices 15% to 20% in January 2018 and ration supply . Record earnings were extrapolated until distributor inventory of six to seven months (normal two to three) forced a collapse in 2019 . Revenue NT$77,156 m in 2018 (+139%) then NT$41,307 m in 2019 (-46.5%); gross margin 63.3% to 35.8%; operating margin 47.8% to 19.4%; net profit about NT$33,840 m to NT$6,945 m . Xpro's FY2027 sits in a supply-shock window. The West Asia conflict raised resin and freight, lifted BOPP and BOPET prices in Q1 FY2027 and encouraged precautionary stocking. UFlex and SRF call Q1 exceptional . Management says full cost neutralisation is "far", and Q2 consolidated EBITDA margin is 9.1% . Treat shock-driven spreads and inventory effects as non-recurring. Test the 13,000 t platform against explicit global-supply and gauge-mix scenarios.

CHAPTER V

Management on Trial — Leading KPIs & Walking the Talk

> *"Our approach is built for the long-term, where returns build as utilization ramps up over time."*
>
> — SIDHARTH BIRLA, CHAIRMAN, XPRO INDIA 29TH AGM REMARKS, 20 JUL 2026

Let me start with a confession about analysis. When a company is spending more on factories than it earns in a year, reported profit tells you very little about what comes next. You and I should watch the dials that move before profit does. For Xpro there are nine such dials, and I want to walk you through the ones that matter most, because they are where this story will either show up or fail to.

The first dial is how full the new Barjora line is. The company doubled its Indian capacity for capacitor film, the thin plastic that sits inside the components that smooth and store power in solar inverters, electric cars and ceiling fans, from 4,000 to 8,000 tonnes a year on 27 March 2026. Picture the stenter hall, the long oven that stretches the film, humming at one end and half asleep at the other. Management says the new line should reach 70 to 80 percent of its rated capacity in the January to March 2027 quarter. In tonnes that is 2,800 to 3,200, my calculation. What we actually know is thinner: output on the new line grew 35 percent quarter on quarter, the line lost about ₹7 crore in the first quarter of this fiscal year, improved by about ₹3 crore in the second, and was profitable at the EBITDA level in October . EBITDA simply means operating profit before depreciation and interest. The company does not publish tonnes for the new line, so the 35 percent cannot be turned into a utilisation figure. That gap is the first thing I would ask about.

The second dial is the price per kilogram, and this one disappoints. From the audited tonnes and sales I get ₹430 a kilo in FY23 and ₹383 a kilo in FY26, an 11 percent fall, even though the story all along has been about thinner, dearer film. Management says it chose to soften prices ahead of new capacity, in its words "a slight softening of prices in anticipation of the creation of new capacities" (C. Bhaskar, 22 May 2026) . Verbally the modal price today is ₹470 to ₹480, with 3.5 micron film above ₹600 and 3 micron near ₹900, but the audited

average has not yet moved. The third dial is profit per tonne. Divide EBITDA by all the tonnes the group produces and you get ₹27,963 in FY23 falling to ₹15,127 in FY26, about 46 percent lower. The first half of this year, at ₹16,131, is a small step up from ₹14,707 a year earlier. So the floor seems to have been found, but a recovery has not yet been shown .

The other dials tell a milder story. The refrigerator-sheet business, which funds everything, grew volumes 26 percent in the September quarter against industry growth of 8 percent. Exports are 4.9 percent of revenue and up 82 percent in the half. Working capital has swollen: the cash conversion cycle, the days between paying suppliers and collecting from customers, went from 33 to 80 days. The new UAE plant has absorbed ₹360 crore of capital that earns nothing until it starts. And a single unnamed customer is 29.6 percent of revenue, which by simple arithmetic must be a refrigerator maker, since its purchases exceed all the capacitor film Xpro sells .

Now to the runway, and I want to be careful, because this is our arithmetic and not management's forecast. Management says India needs about 15,000 tonnes of this film a year and imports roughly 70 percent of it. With 8,000 tonnes in India and 13,000 once the UAE line starts, Xpro alone could in principle supply most of that demand, but it will not be alone: JPFL reports 10,000 tonnes and SRF 4,500, so India has about 22,500 tonnes of capacity chasing 15,000 tonnes of demand . That is why the UAE line matters, and why exports must rise several times over. The bull would say global demand is growing about 7.5 percent a year, 13,000 tonnes is under 10 percent of the world's tonnage, and Xpro already sells where qualification takes months. The skeptic would reply that about 55,000 tonnes of new capacity is coming worldwide against about 59,000 tonnes of demand growth, so a pricing error has nowhere to hide .

So here is the earning power in three cases. In the Low case the new Indian line runs at half and the UAE at 30 percent, at today's ₹383 a kilo and a 20 percent margin: group EBITDA of about ₹76 crore and profit of about ₹20 crore, which is where FY26 was. In the Central case, 80 and 50 percent, ₹430 a kilo and a 30 percent margin, EBITDA is about ₹141 crore and profit about ₹68 crore. In the High case, 90 and 70 percent, ₹480 and a 40 percent margin, EBITDA is about ₹226 crore and profit about ₹131 crore. Notice how wide that is. The two new lines cost about ₹680 crore for about 9,000 tonnes, or ₹7.6 lakh a tonne, and at

₹430 a kilo even full utilisation produces only about 57 paise of revenue per rupee of capital. A 12 percent EBITDA return on that capital needs about 70 percent utilisation at a 30 percent margin. The reassuring part is that the new Indian line only needs to be about a quarter full to cover its own extra depreciation and interest.

Now to the people, because who runs the ramp matters as much as the machines. Sidharth Birla, 68, is executive Chairman. C. Bhaskar, 71, who has been with the businesses for 44 years and made most of the promises we are about to audit, retires as Managing Director on 31 December 2026 and becomes a mentor. Girish Behal, 47, who came from the polyester-film industry in October 2024, is proposed as Managing Director from 1 January 2027, subject to a shareholder vote whose result I could not find . Is that a risk? Yes: the two most experienced operators step back exactly as the ramp starts, and know-how is the moat. Is it an opportunity? Also yes: Mr Behal has run operations since August 2025, so this is a handover and not a surprise, and the 70 to 80 percent utilisation target is the first commitment of his era to be tested.

On governance I find little to alarm me and a few things to notice. The Board has ten directors, five independent, which is exactly the minimum for a promoter-side executive Chairman. The auditor, Walker Chandiok, gives clean opinions and must rotate in 2027. Promoters hold 40.31 percent with nothing pledged, and the fall from 45 percent was dilution, not selling . The cost of seven senior managers was ₹10.19 crore in FY26, a third of standalone profit, and the Chairman's and MD's pay each rose about 12 percent in a year when standalone profit fell 30 percent. The new CEO holds no shares. And the parent has guaranteed ₹256 crore of the UAE subsidiary's euro loan, 36 percent of its own net worth .

Now the part I enjoy most, the walk-the-talk audit. I took 17 statements from the six annual calls, the annual reports and the November 2026 call. In May 2023 Bhaskar said the first new line was "likely to start contributing in FY 2024-2025." It was declared commercial on 27 March 2026. In May 2024 he said "We should be operational definitely in the third quarter of the current fiscal," meaning October to December 2024, and in May 2025 he accepted that September 2025 was "a reasonable assumption" . Three dates, three misses. The UAE line was guided for the second quarter of 2025 and is now at the dry-run stage. The tally: three promises delivered, seven partial, five missed and two too early to call.

What separates those columns? The kept promises were ones management controlled: repaying old bank debt early, turning on solar power ahead of schedule, not returning to the parent's shareholders for more equity, and holding the dividend. The missed ones depended on European machine builders, shipping and commissioning engineers. There is a second pattern: the company will not publish segment margins, tonnes by line or the name of its biggest customer, and some verbal numbers do not match the filings. The ₹106.7 crore of borrowings quoted on the November call leaves out the subsidiary's loan, so the consolidated figure is ₹273.7 crore . And the global demand claim fell from "almost 70 lines, 80 lines" by 2030 in 2023 to "more than 20" in 2026, without explanation .

Why do the machines run late? Management's own explanations are mundane and, I think, believable: supplier-side problems, components damaged in transit that had to be replaced, and recurring external power cuts that slowed the Barjora ramp . On the UAE line the main equipment is installed, but a second team of specialists has to inspect it before dry runs can start. As the Managing Director put it on 4 November 2026, "We are waiting for the Germans to come back, meaning it's a different team." He added that disrupted flights into Dubai were something the company "can't predict" . That is honest. It is also the point: when delivery depends on a handful of European specialists flying into a region at war, the date is a hope, not a schedule. A careful investor builds slack into it, and management's record says the slack needed has been 6 to 21 months.

My independent judgment, then. The financial reporting is dependable: clean opinions, tiny contingent liabilities, no regulatory trouble. The calendar is not. I would treat any management date as the earliest plausible date and expect a quarter or two of slip, which is what the record would predict. This is a judgment about how much weight a timetable deserves, nothing more.

What would raise my confidence? The UAE dry runs starting between December and January. Commercial operations in the UAE by 31 March 2027. The new Indian line reporting tonnes, not only growth rates, for the fourth quarter. Turnover above ₹700 crore for FY27, which needs about ₹349 crore in the second half after ₹351 crore in the first. EBITDA per tonne above ₹16,131. As the Chairman put it at the July 2026 meeting, "Our

approach is built for the long-term, where returns build as utilization ramps up over time." Utilisation is the word to hold on to.

> **NARRATOR'S REFLECTION**
>
> A company can be careful with numbers and optimistic with calendars at the same time. Xpro's audited reporting is clean, its mechanical promises were kept and its project dates were not. The next two quarters supply the cleanest test the record has offered: dry runs, commercial start-up and the first disclosed utilisation of the new Indian line. Until then it is fair to treat the platform's earning power as a range from roughly last year's profit to several times it, depending on utilisation and film mix, not a point estimate.

CHAPTER VI

Following the Cash — 10-Year Financials & Earnings Quality

> *"unrealised non-cash adjustments to Euro denominated borrowings, repayable over 10 years"*
>
> — XPRO INDIA Q1 FY26 INVESTOR RELEASE, 28 JUL 2025, EXPLAINING THE JUNE-QUARTER PROFIT FALL

Now we get to follow the money, and I want you to see it the way an auditor would: not as a story, but as a trail. Xpro's ten-year numbers have a clear shape. Sales roughly doubled, from ₹259 crore in FY15 to ₹505 crore in FY26. Profit climbed to about ₹45 crore a year in FY22 and FY23 and has since fallen to ₹20 crore. Meanwhile the balance sheet more than tripled, from ₹340 crore of assets in FY23 to ₹1,218 crore in FY26. Revenue flat, profit down, assets up three and a half times. How did that happen, and is it the kind of thing that ends well?

Start with the margin. Between FY23 and FY26 revenue barely moved, ₹511 crore to ₹505 crore, but EBITDA, which is operating profit before depreciation and interest, fell from ₹74 crore to ₹47 crore. The margin dropped five points, from 14.6 percent to 9.4 percent. About a point is thinner gross margin. About a point and a half is higher employee cost. Nearly three points is other expenses, up 23 percent while sales did not move. Much of that is staff and overhead built ahead of the new lines, in management's words "higher expenses necessary for the buildup ahead of expansion" (30 May 2025) . The plant that will earn the money is already on the payroll; the money has not arrived.

Then there is the quarter that frightened people. On Screener, the data site that summarises Indian company financials, the June 2025 quarter shows an operating loss of ₹2.5 crore. It looks like a disaster. It was not. The company's own EBITDA that quarter was a positive ₹14.3 crore. The difference is almost exactly the euro loan. Xpro borrowed about 25 million euros to pay for its machines, and when the euro strengthened against the rupee, the accounting rules forced it to mark up what it owed, a loss of about ₹16.8 crore that quarter, none of it cash. The company said so at the time, pointing to "unrealised non-cash adjustments to Euro denominated borrowings, repayable over 10 years" . That is a fair

explanation. But notice the other half of the lesson. Only about a sixth of the exposure was covered by derivatives, so a 1 percent move in the euro is about ₹2.7 crore, and a 10 percent move is about ₹27 crore, close to a whole year's profit before tax. Warren Buffett's line applies: "Only when the tide goes out do you discover who's been swimming naked."

Now read the quarters themselves, with a warning that they are unaudited. From September 2023 to September 2026, sales bounced between ₹96 crore and ₹177 crore a quarter, following refrigerator seasons and plastic-resin prices. The operating margin slid from 15.8 percent in December 2023 to between 8 and 12 percent, apart from the June 2025 distortion. In the half to September 2026 sales were ₹351 crore, up 32.6 percent, EBITDA ₹31 crore and profit ₹14.8 crore against a small loss a year earlier. But the new Barjora line's costs are now in the accounts: in the September quarter depreciation was ₹5.2 crore against ₹3.0 crore and finance cost ₹3.2 crore against ₹1.7 crore. So profit before tax of ₹10.5 crore on sales that were 47 percent higher was only 56 percent above last year's ₹6.7 crore.

Next, what the profit is made of. Of FY26's ₹30 crore pre-tax profit, ₹18 crore, 60 percent, was other income, and 82 percent of that was interest on the cash raised from shareholders. That income shrinks as the cash is spent. Take out other income and the FX loss and underlying pre-tax profit falls from ₹55 crore in FY23 to ₹28 crore in FY26. I would not call that a flaw in the accounts. I would call it the honest size of the business that is already running, with a treasury cushion under it that is being used up. Two more details. The tax rate looks odd, 35.6 percent consolidated against 26.1 percent at the parent, because the losses of the UAE subsidiary earn no tax credit; the subsidiary says it qualifies for the zero-percent free-zone rate, so I expect the gap to narrow once it earns (my inference) . And interest on money borrowed to build an asset is, by the rules, added to the asset's cost until it starts working. The company does not say how much, but by my triangulation about ₹5 crore was capitalised in FY26, 16 to 19 percent of pre-tax profit. The auditors treated it as a key audit matter and accepted it. From late March 2026 that interest is expensed on Barjora, which is one reason finance cost doubled this half.

Then the cash. A profit is an opinion, as accountants say; cash is a fact. In FY23 the business generated ₹83 crore of cash from operations, 111 percent of EBITDA. By FY25 that was ₹13 crore, 25 percent, and FY26 was ₹20 crore, 43 percent. The reason is working capital,

the money tied up in stock and unpaid bills. Inventory days went from 49 to 76, because management holds "at least 3 months of stock in the plant" of a specialty plastic resin that must be imported and is vulnerable to shipping disruption. Supplier days fell from 68 to 46. The cash conversion cycle, the days between paying for materials and collecting from customers, went from 33 to 80. Over FY24 to the first half of this year about ₹78 crore was absorbed. A careful reader would also note that Screener shows a much kinder 99 percent cash conversion for FY26. That divides pre-tax cash flow by an operating profit that already carries the FX loss; after tax, over the company's EBITDA, the number is 43 percent. I read the stocking as policy, a prudent response to a conflict near the Gulf, not manipulation, but it costs cash all the same.

Now the balance sheet. A housekeeping point first. Screener's September 2026 column shows fixed assets of ₹712 crore and construction in progress of ₹44 crore. These appear swapped. The company's own statement shows plant of ₹351 crore, leased land of ₹44 crore and construction in progress, CWIP for short, of ₹360 crore. The ₹712 crore is plant plus CWIP and the ₹44 crore is the lease. CWIP is the UAE plant, still being built and earning nothing. I use the company's numbers throughout.

On debt, the picture changed from almost nothing to meaningful. Gross borrowings were ₹36 crore in March 2023 and ₹289 crore in March 2026, eight times as much. They are almost all euro loans backed by European export-credit agencies, at 3.84 percent fixed or the euro interbank rate plus 1.21 percent. Cash and bank balances were ₹300 crore in March and ₹233 crore in September, so the group went from net cash of ₹12 crore to net debt of ₹40 crore. Interest cover, the number of times operating profit covers interest, fell from 8.4 to 3.2 times. On the 4 November call management said "Total borrowings stood at INR106.7 crores." That is the parent only. The consolidated figure is ₹273.7 crore, because the UAE subsidiary carries about ₹154 crore of its own, which the parent guarantees up to ₹256 crore. About ₹125 crore of the group's March cash sat in that subsidiary.

When does the bill arrive? The subsidiary's own audited accounts, which I read, show that its loan begins repaying in April 2027, and consolidated current borrowings add up only if that is true. So the burden is gentler this year and heavier from FY28: roughly ₹39 crore a year of principal and interest on today's drawn amounts, against an operating cash flow of ₹20 crore

last year. Until the new lines earn, the cash is the bridge. And on 13 November 2026 the company sent shareholders a postal ballot to refinance the subsidiary's debt into facilities from the Emirates Development Bank, with a parent guarantee up to 83 million dirhams and room for another ₹60 crore of loans and ₹60 crore of equity or loans. A skeptic reads that as a sign the funding is not finished. A bull reads it as ordinary treasury management by a company that kept its rating at A-.

Does the new capital earn its keep? I use a hurdle I want to be explicit about: a 12 percent cost of capital, which is my assumption, not the company's. Return on invested capital, ROIC, which is the after-tax operating profit on the capital working in the business, was about 21 percent in FY23 and 3.4 percent in FY26. Against 12 percent that is a surplus of ₹21 crore in FY23 and a shortfall of ₹70 crore in FY26. The equity base grew 3.4 times while EBITDA fell by a third. To earn a 12 percent EBITDA return on the ₹680 crore for the two new lines, about 70 percent use at a 30 percent margin and ₹430 a kilo is needed. To earn a 12 percent after-tax return, near-full use at a 40 percent margin. Those are the stakes.

A quick check on shares, because people stumble here. The share count is 1.18 crore in 2022 and 2.35 crore in 2026, not 11.8 and 23.5; those are the share capital in rupee crore. Half the increase was a free bonus, so the true dilution is about 32 percent. Yet earnings per share fell 68 percent while profit fell 56 percent. Book value per share went from about ₹97 to ₹324. The dividend stayed at ₹2 a share for five years, ₹20 crore in total, 4.6 percent of the ₹440 crore raised. Charlie Munger said, "Show me the incentives and I'll show you the outcome." Here the money went into factories, not into payouts.

Now the full trail, FY22 to FY26. The business generated ₹209 crore of operating cash. Shareholders added ₹440 crore at the parent and ₹80 crore at the UAE subsidiary. That funded ₹507 crore of capex, and what remained went into deposits and cash. In May 2024 Bhaskar said "Our cash generation looks strong enough to have supported it without these raises." The record is ₹77 crore of cash generation over three years against about ₹465 crore of capex. The raises were not optional, and they arrived early: ₹300 crore of cash, 68 percent of what the parent raised, was still on the balance sheet in March 2026.

Let me walk you through the scorecard the way I would an examiner's checklist. Two lines are green: the unmodified audit opinion, and the related-party dealings, pledges and contingent

liabilities, which come to dividends only, nothing, and about ₹5 crore, under 1 percent of net worth . Six lines are amber, meaning worth watching rather than worrying: the undisclosed capitalised interest, the dependence on other income, the cash conversion, the leverage and guarantees, the dilution, and the consistency of disclosure. On that last one, the company's own fourth-quarter deck swapped two lines for March 2025, showing leased land as ₹344.5 crore and construction in progress as ₹37.0 crore when the audited figures are the reverse; return on capital for FY26 appears as 5.3 percent in one document and 5.7 percent in another. These are presentation errors, not accounting ones, but a careful reader likes consistency . One is red: the unhedged euro exposure.

How would a bull and a skeptic each read the cash burn? The bull says free cash flow of minus ₹274 crore and minus ₹120 crore is the price of building two lines that management says will each add ₹150 to ₹200 crore of revenue , that the parent itself was roughly self-funding in FY26 and the burn sat in the subsidiary, and that the debt is low-coupon and long-dated. The skeptic answers that operating cash flow was only ₹33 crore across the two years, that capex ran at 13 times it, that the UAE plant is well over a year behind its first guidance, and that every quarter of delay adds interest and depreciation without revenue. Both are describing the same numbers. The difference is the date the UAE plant starts and how quickly the new Barjora line fills.

So what is my verdict? On accounting quality I give a green. The audit is clean, tax is paid, related-party flows are small and nothing is pledged. On economic earnings quality I would say it is weaker than the headline: the operating base is about ₹28 crore before other income and FX, not ₹30 crore plus. On the balance sheet, the risk is not that it is weak today, because it is not. It is that it rests on euro debt that is largely uncovered, a parent guarantee and a ₹358 crore plant that has to start. The one red flag in my scorecard is that exposure, and it is a risk of volatility, not of dishonesty. A balance sheet can absorb a few quarters of delay. It cannot absorb many.

NARRATOR'S REFLECTION

The tidy way to read this chapter is that the accounts are honest and the business is in transition. Honest accounts mean you can trust the trail: raise equity early, spend it on factories, let the margin sag while costs arrive before volume. What the trail cannot tell you is whether the new lines will earn their cost. For that you need the numbers this chapter keeps pointing to: utilisation, realisation and the date the UAE plant starts. Until they arrive, a margin of safety lives in the cash on the balance sheet and in the export-credit terms of the debt, and both have limits.

CHAPTER VII

Why the Stock Trades Here — Market Expectations vs. Peers

> *"In the short run, the market is a voting machine but in the long run it is a weighing machine."*
>
> — BEN GRAHAM, AS QUOTED BY WARREN BUFFETT, BERKSHIRE HATHAWAY SHAREHOLDER LETTER FOR 1987

Let me open with the question under every valuation: what does the price already assume? Ben Graham's old line, which Warren Buffett repeated in his 1987 letter, is that “In the short run, the market is a voting machine but in the long run it is a weighing machine” . This chapter does the weighing for Xpro. A word on dates first. Our verified cutoff is Thursday 12 November 2026, when the shares closed at ₹1,142.20. A later print on Friday, ₹1,190.10, up 4.19% on thin volume, exists, but every number I give you uses the Thursday close unless I say otherwise .

Start with plain arithmetic. Market capitalisation is price times shares: ₹1,142.20 times 2.347 crore shares, or ₹2,680.8 crore. Add net debt, which is borrowings of ₹273.7 crore plus leases of ₹42.3 crore less cash of ₹233.4 crore, so ₹82.6 crore, and the ₹38.7 crore that belongs to minority holders of the UAE subsidiary, and you get enterprise value, or EV, about ₹2,802 crore. EV is what it would cost to buy the whole business, debts included. Now divide by earnings. Trailing twelve-month earnings per share are ₹15.02, so the price-to-earnings ratio, the P/E, is 76.0 times. On the audited FY2026 EPS of ₹8.19 it is 139.5 times. EV over operating profit of ₹57.5 crore is 48.7 times, EV over sales of ₹591.8 crore is 4.73 times, and price over book value of about ₹330 a share is 3.46 times .

Said another way, for every ₹100 you pay you receive about ₹1.30 of annual profit. That would be easier to accept if returns on capital were high. They are not. Return on capital employed is 3.78% and return on equity 2.8% on the Screener data, and the company reports 5.3 to 5.7% for FY2026 . Compare that with the 12% cost of capital I assumed in Chapter 6. You are paying three and a half times book value for a business that currently earns well below what its capital costs.

How did we get here? From its listing in April 2004 to March 2020 the share closed between ₹8.5 and ₹55 . Then came fiscal 2022. The close went from ₹48.7 to ₹977.9, twenty-fold, while earnings per share rose about five-fold, from ₹4.72 to ₹25.38. The P/E went from 10.3 times to 38.5 times. Dielectric prices and mix had turned, as Chapter 1 showed, and the market paid a far higher multiple for the new earnings power.

Now watch what happened after earnings peaked. EPS was ₹24.91 in FY2023, then ₹19.91, ₹17.04 and ₹8.19. At each March year-end the P/E was 27.8, 56.1, 68.8 and 123.6 times. The price peaked at ₹1,634.4 on 17 December 2024, fell 50.3% to ₹813.0 on 13 March 2026, bounced to ₹1,503.6 on 2 July, dropped to ₹963.6 on 2 November, and climbed 14.6% after the Q2 results. Set 31 March 2023 beside today: the price is up 65%, while EPS is down 67% on FY2026 and 40% on the trailing twelve months. Every rupee of that gain is a higher multiple. Buffett, quoting Graham again, put it as “Price is what you pay; value is what you get” . The market is paying for the ramp, not for earnings delivered.

So let me turn the question around, the way an investor does with a reverse DCF. Instead of forecasting and then valuing, I ask what has to be true for this price to make sense. If you would pay 25 times for a mature business, ₹2,681 crore of market value needs about ₹107 crore of annual profit. At 40 times it needs ₹67 crore, at 20 times ₹134 crore. Trailing profit is ₹35 crore. In Chapter 5 I built three cases for the full 13,000-tonne platform: Low at ₹20 crore, Central at ₹68 crore and High at ₹131 crore. Only the High case clears the 25-times hurdle.

Now add the return you would want. Assume 12% a year, my hurdle. The price must reach ₹1,499 by March 2029 and ₹1,679 by March 2030. If the market then pays 25 times, earnings per share must be ₹60, which is ₹141 crore of profit in FY2029. At 30 times it is ₹117 crore, at 20 times ₹176 crore. That is 3.4 to 5.0 times what the company earns now, within 2.4 years.

Which case does the price match? Add one more, the management-range case: new-line dielectric revenue of ₹350 crore plus the old line's ₹135.5 crore at a 35% EBITDA margin, and Coex at ₹370 crore and 6%. That gives EBITDA near ₹192 crore and profit near ₹106 crore, so today's market value is 25.3 times it. At a 28-times exit, a 12% return needs about ₹126 crore, 92% of the way from my Central case to my High case. The management-range

case would earn about 4% a year. The price therefore corresponds to the High case: both new lines nearly full, thin film near ₹480 a kilogram and a 40% margin, against audited ₹383 and an implied 16 to 22% in FY2026. Management has been candid about the gap: “One is a volume ramp-up and one is a value ramp-up. They are independent of each other, but both need to happen before we realize the full value” . The price assumes both, on schedule.

Here is a point worth slowing down for. Even my Central case earns about ₹73 crore after tax on roughly ₹830 crore of capital, a return of 8.8%, below the 12% cost. A company that earns less than its cost of capital destroys value when it grows. The textbook identity, from Mauboussin and Rappaport's expectations method and Damodaran's work, makes the point exactly: with no growth, a business is worth its earnings divided by its cost of capital, which at 12% is 8.3 times, and growth below the hurdle lowers that . My Base multiple of 28 times is therefore 3.4 times the no-growth anchor, and I call it generous because it pays for thin-gauge, UAE and later-line upside that the Central case does not contain. For the High case, with a return of 16.4%, 30 times needs about 10.9% growth sustained for a long time. That is a runway assumption, not a steady state.

Now compare Xpro with its neighbours, with the warning that none is a pure capacitor-film company. SRF trades at 32.1 times earnings with an 18.8% operating margin and a 14.6% return on capital; it is also a rival, with 4,500 tonnes commissioned in May 2026 . Garware Hi-Tech, the best quality benchmark, trades at 41.0 times with a 20.9% margin and an 18.1% return; it held 17 to 21% margins through the cycle but makes polyester film . Cosmo First trades at 10.0 times, Polyplex at 19.3 times, and Jindal Poly Films is loss-making after its 2025 fire. Xpro, on the 13 November print, trades at 79.3 times with a 6.3% operating margin and a 3.8% return on capital.

Divide each P/E by its return on capital and the picture is stark. Xpro pays about 21 turns of P/E for every point of return, SRF about 2.2, Garware 2.3 and Cosmo 0.9. Xpro is about nine times as expensive as SRF and Garware on this crude yardstick. Only Polyplex, with a 0.9% return and a 3.9% margin, is as expensive per point, at a quarter of Xpro's multiple. I read the premium as a scarcity and option premium on specialty capacitor film and on a doubling of capacity, not a price for what the company earns today. One more cross-check: EV of ₹2,802 crore is ₹21.6 lakh per tonne of nameplate, while Xpro's two new lines cost ₹7.6 lakh per

tonne and SRF's about ₹6.2 lakh. EV also pays for Coex, but rivals can still add capacity for well under half that value.

So what is each case worth? The Low case, ₹20 crore of profit, is a 3% return, so a P/E means nothing; I value it at 1.2 times the book value I expect by March 2028, about ₹345 a share, which is ₹414, 63.8% below the price. The Base case, ₹68 crore or ₹29 of EPS at 28 times, is ₹811, 29.0% below. The Bull case, ₹131 crore or ₹55.8 of EPS at 30 times, is ₹1,674, 46.6% above. Those profits are before the 15% UAE minority, so all three are slightly generous. Move the Base multiple from 22 to 32 times and the value runs from ₹637 to ₹927, never reaching the price. To earn 12% a year to March 2028 the share would have to be ₹1,336, and only the Bull case clears that.

Let me give the bull his best day. Xpro is the largest Indian capacitor-film maker, with a 13,000-tonne platform once the UAE line starts, in a market that imports about 70% of its film. Net debt is only ₹40 crore against ₹813 crore of equity, the rating is A-, management does not see a parent equity raise, and Q2 revenue rose 47% . The UAE line, thin film at ₹600 to ₹900 a kilogram and the later lines are real options. Management itself says it chose “a slight softening of prices in anticipation of the creation of new capacities” , which a bull reads as buying volume ahead of rivals. At the top of the margin range, the High case earns ₹131 crore and today's value is 20.5 times it.

Now the skeptic's best day. Seventy-six times earnings, 3.5 times book, a 3.8% return. Even my Central case earns less than the cost of capital. India has about 22,500 tonnes of nameplate for 15,000 tonnes of demand, every start-up date has slipped by 6 to 21 months, the implied dielectric margin is 16 to 23% against a quoted 35 to 55%, and management accepts price flexibility “even at the risk of occasional impact on margins” . Buffett's 1989 advice was that it is “far better to buy a wonderful company at a fair price than a fair company at a wonderful price” . The question is not whether Xpro is a decent business. It is whether this price is fair for it.

My independent view, in a sentence: the price already capitalises the High case and leaves no room for the slippage that has been the pattern, and the Base value of ₹811 is 29% below it. The valuation does not support paying for the Central case. The final decision is made in Chapter 9. What would make me revisit? A disclosed dielectric margin above 30% with the

new Indian line at 70% or more utilisation, the UAE line capitalised on schedule by 31 March 2027, or a lower price: the Base value earns 12% a year only from about ₹694.

> **NARRATOR'S REFLECTION**
>
> A price is a forecast somebody else has already made. At ₹1,142 the forecast is that Xpro fills both new lines, sells thinner and dearer film and earns about ₹130 crore, nearly four times what it earns now, and that the market will still pay close to thirty times that profit. You do not need to disagree with the story to see the risk: you only need to notice that the earnings have to arrive on time, and Chapter 5 showed that the calendar is where this management has been weakest.

CHAPTER VIII

Reading the Tape — Trend, Volume & Momentum Opportunity

> *"It never was my thinking that made the big money for me. It always was my sitting."*
>
> — EDWIN LEFÈVRE, REMINISCENCES OF A STOCK OPERATOR (1923), THE LIVERMORE CHARACTER ON PATIENCE

A chart does not tell you what a business is worth, only what other people have been willing to pay and how eagerly. So this chapter has a narrow job: to ask whether the tape is giving us a good moment to act. First, the housekeeping. The verified session cutoff for this dossier is Thursday 12 Nov 2026, the last day the benchmark bar was confirmed, and the ledger closes the share at ₹1,142.20. By the time I am writing, a later 13 Nov print from TradingView shows ₹1,190.10, up 4.19%, on volume of only 0.60 times the 30-day average . I keep the 12 Nov numbers as my anchor and treat the later print as a test of them.

Is this a fresh advance, or a stock catching its breath inside something bigger? My answer is the second. The share fell 50.3% from its closing high of ₹1,634.4 in December 2024 to ₹813.0 in March 2026. It rebounded to ₹1,503.6 in July, fell back to ₹963.6 on 2 Nov, and then jumped 14.6% to ₹1,142.20 after the Q2 results . That is not a staircase. It is a roller coaster that is now parked under a ceiling of flat averages.

To read the ceiling, borrow a map from Stan Weinstein, who divided a stock's life into four stages . In Stage 1 the stock goes sideways after a decline and the 30-week average, the simple average of thirty weekly closes, flattens. In Stage 2 the price climbs above a rising 30-week average on growing volume; that is where the big money is made. In Stage 3 the average flattens again and the price chops around it as the buyers tire. In Stage 4 the price slides under a falling average. A stage is a description of where you are in the story, not a prediction.

The data sources disagree about where Xpro sits, and I think you should see the disagreement rather than a tidy answer. Our market-facts ledger says Stage 3, a topping or pullback pattern. TradingView's stage tool says Stage 1, with the stock consolidating near the 30-week average at ₹1,195.66 and a support zone of ₹1,105.64 to ₹1,150.62. A separate

TradingView text label says the trend is broken below both the 50-day and 200-day averages, but its own numbers put the price about 5% above the 50-day and 6% above the 200-day, so that label is out of date. TheWrap's Stage 2 dashboard, built on data to 8 Nov, does not list the stock at all among 465 names .

My own call is a late Stage 3 to 4 slide that has become a Stage 1 base attempt. The 30-week average peaked at ₹1,249.2 in June 2025, sank to ₹1,002.8 in May 2026, and has crept back to ₹1,193.0, flat over the last four weeks. Over the last 52 weeks the share closed 26 weeks above and 26 weeks below that line. The last weekly close above it was ₹1,197.1 on 25 Sep. That is a stock that has stopped falling, not yet a stock that has started rising.

Now the picture of the averages. The close of ₹1,142.20 is 0.8% above the 50-day (₹1,132.88, falling by about 3.5% in twenty sessions), 1.8% above the 200-day (₹1,121.65, rising slightly), 3.0% above the 10-week exponential average of ₹1,109.0 and almost exactly on the 40-week exponential average of ₹1,143.8. It is 4.3% below the 30-week average. When five averages bunch together within a few percent, the stock is not trending, it is deciding. Only 15% of the last 60 sessions closed above the 50-day average, so the decision has gone against the bulls more often than not.

What about volume, the footprint of institutions? On 4 Nov, results day, 273,535 shares changed hands, 2.7 times the prior 20-day average, and the share rose 10.7% in one session. That is a real burst of demand. But look at what followed: 55,579 shares on 6 Nov, then 31,444, and 56,720 on 12 Nov, when the share rose 3.22% on only 0.49 times its 20-day average. A rise on half the normal turnover does not suggest that buyers are lining up. The up-day to down-day volume ratio of 2.04 sounds friendly, but it is driven by that one spike, and the ledger counts five distribution days in the last 25 sessions .

The shareholding table adds a footnote, not a headline. Domestic institutions rose from 2.94% to 3.89% in the September quarter, a gain of 0.95 points or about 2.2 lakh shares by our arithmetic. Promoters held at 40.32% and foreign institutions edged from 13.81% to 13.79% . The annual report lists Malabar India Fund Ltd at 11.33% ; if that fund is counted in the foreign line, about 82% of foreign ownership sits with one name. The quarter ended on 30 Sep, so none of this explains the November volume, and I retrieved no bulk-deal or block-deal data to tell you who bought on results day. I would rather say so than guess.

Relative strength is where the honesty gets uncomfortable. The Nifty 50 is in an uptrend, though with narrow breadth: 76.8% of its breadth pool is above the 50-day average and nine of eleven sectors are above their 20-day and 50-day averages . Against that, Xpro trails the index by 2.11% over 63 sessions and 13.54% over 28 sessions. It is a laggard in a rising market. Even the last two weeks, when the share gained 14.11%, have only started to repair a gap.

Look at the shorter timeframes and the picture brightens. The weekly RSI, a 0 to 100 gauge of momentum, is 52, neutral. The daily reads 59.7 on the ledger and 63.4 on the later print, and the 4-hour chart reads 67.7 with the price above its 4-hour 20-period average of ₹1,104.96, an intraday turn up . Bollinger bandwidth, a measure of how wide the price swings are against their norm, is 23.2%, and the daily range is 4.7% of the price. Good setups usually show swings narrowing and volume drying up at the lows, a pattern traders call volatility contraction. Here the swings are still wide: the 63-session closing range runs from ₹963.6 to ₹1,389.7, a 44.2% spread. Daily momentum turned up first, which is how recoveries start, but the weekly chart decides the stage, and it has not turned.

Where would the market argue the point? On the upside, the first ceiling is ₹1,195 to ₹1,200, where the 30-week average and the 13 Nov intraday high of about ₹1,196.50 meet. Above that sit the ₹1,264.6 pivot, the ₹1,310 to ₹1,389.7 zone of 63-session highs, the July high of ₹1,503.6 and the 52-week high of ₹1,574.8. Below, the floor is ₹1,105 to ₹1,110, where the 10-week and 4-hour averages cluster, then the 20-day average at ₹1,030, the November low of ₹963.6, the 20-day swing low of ₹940.1, the pivots at ₹913.8 and ₹817.8, and finally the March trough of ₹813.0. The stock is boxed between a floor 3% below and a ceiling 5% above.

Is there a trade in that box? Not a clean one, in my judgment. Suppose you bought at ₹1,142.20 and placed a stop just under ₹1,105. You would risk ₹37.2, or 3.26% of the entry price, to make ₹53.5 or 4.68% at the ceiling, a ratio of 1.44 to 1, which has to win about 41% of the time to break even. The 4.5 to 1 payoff to ₹1,310 exists only if the ₹1,195 ceiling gives way, and nothing about 0.6 times average volume says it will. Buy the 13 Nov print at ₹1,190.10 with the same stop and you risk ₹85.1, or 7.15% of the entry price, for 0.88 to 1 to the next pivot at ₹1,264.6. And a stop only 0.7 of an average daily range away is noise, not

protection. Marks has a line I find useful here: 'You can't predict. You can prepare.' The preparation is to know your levels before the market tests them.

Let me give you the bull and the bear each in their best form. The bull says: the 4-hour chart turned, the daily momentum is healthy, results-day demand was real, the 200-day average is rising, and the stock sits within half a percent of the 30-week line after a 23.5% rise from the November low. The bear says: the stock trails the market, the 50-day is falling, volume faded to half of normal on the rally, overhead supply from 2025 is untested, the weekly chart is neutral, and this stock has already shown it can lose half its value. I find the bear's case stronger on evidence and the bull's case stronger on timing, which is why I would say 'wait for proof'.

What would settle it? A weekly close above ₹1,200 on weekly volume of at least 1.5 times the average week, about 8.6 lakh shares, would turn the structure into a genuine Stage 2 candidate, with ₹1,310 to ₹1,390 as the next repair zone. A close back under ₹1,105 to ₹1,110 would cancel the attempt and reopen ₹963.6 and ₹940.1. Graham's old line applies: 'In the short run, the market is a voting machine but in the long run it is a weighing machine.' On this chart the voting machine has begun to count again, but the votes are few. Even Chairman Sidharth Birla frames the business on a longer clock: 'Our approach is built for the long-term, where returns build as utilization ramps up over time' . The tape, for now, is simply not on that clock. One last practical point: the stock is not in the NSE futures and options segment, so there is no listed options market to express a view, and any position is a plain equity exposure with the full drawdown history above.

> **NARRATOR'S REFLECTION**
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> A bounce is not a trend, and a chart cannot tell you how good the business is. This one tells us that the sellers of 2025 have not been cleared, that buyers appeared on results day but did not stay, and that the market has not yet voted for a new advance. Waiting for volume to confirm costs a few percent of upside. Buying before it does risks re-learning what a 50% drawdown feels like.

CHAPTER IX

Bull vs. Bear, Likely Outcomes & Our Action Plan

> *"“Price is what you pay; value is what you get.”"*
>
> — WARREN BUFFETT, BERKSHIRE HATHAWAY SHAREHOLDER LETTER FOR 2008, QUOTING BEN GRAHAM

Let me put two analysts at the table with you, one who loves this business and one who has been burned by businesses like it. The first says: look at the revenue, up 47% in the September quarter, look at the new line making money, look at a balance sheet that is nearly debt-free. The second says: look at the price. Both are right, and our job is to work out what each fact is worth in rupees per share. I would like you to follow that arithmetic with me, because the answer is not a matter of mood.

Start with what the bull gets right. India imports about 70% of its capacitor film, and Xpro is the one domestic maker with a real platform, 13,000 tonnes by 2027 if the UAE plant starts . The Managing Director told the November call that “we expect during the fourth quarter this year to be operating the new line at between 70% to 80% of its rated capacity” . If that happens, each extra thousand tonnes sold at ₹430 a kilo adds ₹43.0 Cr of revenue and about ₹12.9 Cr of EBITDA at a 30% margin, and most of the cost is already in the accounts. Run management's own ranges and you get a profit of about ₹106 Cr, and today's value of the whole company is 25 times that.

Now ask what the bear gets right, because it is more than people expect. The stock trades at 76 times last year's earnings and 3.5 times book value, on a business that earned 3.8% on its capital in the latest year. Garware, a specialty-film maker earning an 18% return on capital, trades at 41 times; SRF, with a 15% return, trades at 32 times . Since March 2023 the shares have risen 65% while earnings per share fell 67%, which means every rupee of that gain is hope, not profit .

Return on capital is the heart of it. Chapter 6 showed that the company earned about 21% on its invested capital in FY2023 and only 3.4% in FY2026, because roughly ₹700 Cr was poured into two film lines that are not yet full . Even in our central case, with Barjora's new

line at 80% and the UAE line at 50%, the return reaches about 8.8%, still below the 12% a shareholder should demand. Charlie Munger's advice was “Invert, always invert.” So invert: how would an investor lose money here? By paying for the central case at the success-case price, which is exactly what the current price asks.

Then there is the habit of the calendar. Barjora Line 2 arrived about 15 months late. The UAE line is already 18 to 21 months behind its first public date. Management's financial promises have been kept, repaying the banks early and funding the build without a rights issue, and its commissioning dates have not . I do not call that dishonesty; I call it a base rate. When a team has been late three times, you do not assume the fourth schedule is the one that holds, and you certainly do not pay 76 times earnings for it.

Supply is the third worry. India can now make about 22,500 tonnes of capacitor film between Xpro, Jindal's JPFL Films and SRF, against demand of about 15,000 tonnes, and imports still come in at zero duty . When Xpro decided to cut prices by 6% to 7% in advance of its own new capacity, it was telling you something about who sets the price. Chapter 4's Jindal and Treofan story is the cautionary tale: a family that built film capacity into a soft market and watched an operating margin of 24% fall to zero.

So I did what I ask you to do with any story you love: I wrote three futures and weighed them. In the bear future, 30% likely, the UAE line slips again and new Indian capacity forces prices down, and the shares are worth about ₹414, which is about 1.2 times book. In the base future, 50% likely, the new lines fill at roughly management's pace at a 30% margin, profit reaches about ₹68 Cr, and at 28 times earnings the shares are worth about ₹811. In the bull future, 20% likely, management's ranges arrive early, profit reaches about ₹131 Cr, and at 30 times the shares are worth about ₹1,674. Weigh them and you get ₹865, which is 24% below the ₹1,142.20 close.

Test that against a hostile question. What if management simply does what it says? I re-based the base case to the management-range profit and gave the bull case more weight, and the weighted value came to about ₹1,197, a mere 5% above the close. In the world where the company is right, the stock is fairly priced; in every other world it is expensive. For the bull case alone to equal today's price, it would need a 52% chance when I give it 20%.

You may think my weights are too harsh, so try yours. Give the bear case only 20%, the base case 45% and the bull case 35%, a far friendlier set than the evidence supports, and the weighted value is ₹1,034, still 9.5% below the close. It takes a combination of the management-range profit, a high bull weight and a 28 times multiple on the base to bring the arithmetic back to today's price or slightly above, and that combination is a forecast that everything goes right.

Let me translate the three time horizons into plain words. If you trade for weeks or months, there is no edge today: the nearest ceiling at ₹1,195.7 is only 4.7% above the close, and a sensible stop at ₹1,105 is 3.3% below it, a ratio of 1.4 to 1 that I would not take . If you invest for the next one to two years, the inflection is real and checkable, because Barjora's ramp, the UAE start and the first margin disclosure all arrive within about six months; but the stock rose 14.6% in the six sessions after the September results, which is the market paying for that inflection before it is visible . And if you are a five-year compounder, the single question is whether ₹700 Cr earns more than it costs, and nothing reported before 2028 will answer it.

If you want to follow Xpro without owning it, I would track four numbers every quarter and ignore the headlines. First, the utilisation of the new Barjora line, which management has said it will report against a 70% to 80% target . Second, the share of dielectric film in revenue, which was 26.8% in FY2026 and has to climb if the margin story is real. Third, EBITDA per tonne, ₹15,127 in FY2026 and ₹16,131 in the first half of FY2027 against ₹27,963 in FY2023 (our calculation) . Fourth, the cash conversion cycle, which stretched from 33 days to 80 as the company stocked three months of imported resin . If the first three rise while the fourth falls, the central case is working.

I would add one more word about alternatives, because a rejection invites the question of what to do instead. The honest answer today is nothing, and nothing is a position. XPROINDIA is not in the NSE F&O segment, so there is no call spread or LEAPS to size a small bet cheaply, and the cash-equity version of the same bet is the one the numbers decline. This report did not underwrite a shortlist name or an outside candidate to the same standard, so the plan keeps the next marginal rupee in cash rather than inventing a destination.

That is why my verdict is REJECTED, and let me be careful about what that word means here. It is not a judgment that Xpro is a bad company; Chapter 6 found clean accounts and a sturdy balance sheet, and Pass 1 rated the business conditional, not failed. It is a judgment that the price leaves no room for error. The usual hedge would be to wait for the stock to pull back to support near ₹1,105 to ₹1,150. But our base value of ₹811 sits below that whole zone, so waiting there gains you nothing. I will only call a price attractive where the reward is at least one and a half times the risk, and on our numbers that is around ₹620 to ₹660, with a stop at ₹560.

The chart agrees that there is no rush. The stock fell 50% from its December 2024 peak, bounced hard, and is now pressing up against a ceiling of flat moving averages between ₹1,120 and ₹1,195, on thin volume . One further day made it look better: after the 13 November close the TradingView print was ₹1,190.10, up 4.2%, but still on 0.6 times average volume and still just under the 30-week average . A clean weekly close above ₹1,200 on strong volume would be the first piece of evidence worth acting on; a close under ₹1,105 would say the retest failed.

What about you? The holdings ledger shows no Xpro shares, so there is nothing to sell and no stop to set; the right action for new money is to keep it in cash until either the price or the evidence changes. I have set alerts for exactly those moments: the price entering ₹620 to ₹660, the Barjora line reporting 70% utilisation with a disclosed dielectric margin above 30%, and the UAE line being switched on. Howard Marks said you can't predict but you can prepare, and this plan is preparation: it names what would change my mind and the number at which it would.

Current holding decision: NOT HELD. NOT HELD (0 shares); no current holding to trim or exit.. The same-session positions ledger lists 18 Zerodha positions, and XPROINDIA is not one of them. There is no holding to keep, trim or exit and no stop to ratchet. No purchase is recommended. The base-case value of ₹811 sits below the whole technical support zone. The probability-weighted value of ₹865 is 24.3% below the 12 November close. If shares are held in an account outside this ledger, treat a daily close below ₹1,105 as the first review line. Treat the ₹960-940 zone as the second. These are advisory alerts, not broker orders. Alert plan: Weekly close above the 30-week average and overhead resistance cluster on weekly

volume of at least 1.5x the average week (about 8.6 lakh shares) — Re-run the tape review; the valuation gate still fails, so this is a monitoring event and not an entry.; Daily close below the 50-day average / 10-week EMA support area — Treat the retest as failed; next downside shelf is ₹960-940, then ₹913.8 and the ₹813.0 March 2026 closing low. No shares are held, so nothing is sold.; Price enters the re-underwriting zone — Re-run the full underwriting with a fresh same-session snapshot; at ₹660 the base case offers 1.51:1 against a ₹560 stop.; Q3 FY2027 results and UAE dry-run update (February 2027) — Check Barjora Line 2 utilisation against the 70-80% target, the UAE schedule, any disclosed dielectric margin and cash conversion.; UAE commercial production declared (guided by 31 March 2027) — Recompute central-case PAT: capitalisation of about ₹358 Cr starts depreciation and interest; re-underwrite only if utilisation and margin evidence also improve. Capital redeployment: 0.00% to SHORTLIST (SHORTLIST): No active-shortlist name is funded from this marginal cash unit.; Fund a shortlist name only after a fresh same-session snapshot, a documented business verdict and a support-zone asymmetry of at least 1.5:1.; 0.00% to OUTSIDE (OUTSIDE): No outside candidate is funded.; Fund an outside name only after a separate evidence-backed company review clears the same hurdles.; 100.00% to CASH (CASH): Retain the entire next marginal unit in cash.; Reallocate when Xpro India enters ₹620-660, or when another equity candidate clears current evidence, valuation and technical gates.

Options and Call-Convexity Playbook (NOT OPTIONABLE OR ILLIQUID): XPROINDIA has no liquid listed options chain (not in NSE F&O segment) — express any thesis strictly via cash equity.

> **NARRATOR'S REFLECTION**
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> A rejection is not a prediction that the stock will fall. It is a statement that, at this price, you are being paid for the best case and being asked to carry the rest. Notice how different that feels from disliking a business. The most useful discipline in this chapter is to hold two thoughts together: Xpro may well deliver what it promises, and it may still be the wrong thing to buy today.

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